

1923–1929

ROARING TWENTIES

Despite the brevity of their reign, knee-length evening gowns sprinkled with beads and paillettes are probably the main garments associated with the Roaring Twenties. Hems moved upwards during 1923, peaking just below the knee a few years later – only to inch towards the ground again almost immediately. As sleeves were abandoned, women invested in safety razors and tried out the new deodorants. The French designer Jean Patou remarked that it was “the taste for dancing” that determined the line of evening gowns. It also influenced their decoration – beaded fringes and feathers attached to thin crêpes and georgettes swayed to the rhythm of the Charleston and Black Bottom. For a few years everything glittered: real diamonds or rhinestones decorated tiaras, bandeaus, and detachable heels. Anticipated by pointed hems and trailing shawls attached at the waist or shoulder, the long evening gown returned by the end of the decade; the dancing was over.



Reptile English-born couturier Edward Molyneux created this unique dress. A variety of beads are used to make the fabric appear as if made from snakeskin. Long, triangular inserts emanating from the skirt underneath the hips end in beaded fringes.

Multicoloured embroidery

Black edging

1927

Shawl falls from shoulders to give longer hem at back

Pointed hem This dress marks the transition stage between the short, straight evening dress and the longer gowns of the end of the decade. Round at the front, the neckline turns into a low V at the back, where shawls of transparent fabric hang from the shoulders to below the hemline.

Matching shoes

Slip-on design

Low waist accentuated with belt

1925

Geometric patterns above hem

Layers Evening dresses of this period often consisted of two garments. Here, a silver lamé foundation shines through the lace fabric of the overdress. The entire gown is covered in tiny red and pink bugle beads.

Waist not marked

Scalloped hem

Chiffon The deliberately asymmetric hem of this chiffon dress is echoed in the irregular embroidery consisting of a semi-abstract floral design. This beaded pattern seems to be expanding, which gives the appearance of movement.